

Day 2 — Three Doṣas in Detail

Module: Doṣas · **Band:** Middle · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

By the end of this lesson, students name three qualities of each *doṣa*, one main bodily site, and one observable everyday sign of each, and explain why those qualities follow logically from the element pairing.

Materials

- The class *tridoṣa* poster (large, on the wall)
- Whiteboard for the qualities table
- Exit-ticket slips

Vocabulary introduced today

- *guṇa* (IAST: guṇa; lit. “quality, attribute”) — a property of a substance or process. We met *guṇa* lightly in Module 2; in Ayurveda, each *doṣa* is identified by a set of *guṇas*.

Lesson flow

Warm-up (5 min)

- Recall: “*What are the three doṣas, and what does each one do?*” Whole-class chorus.
- “*Today: what does each one actually feel like?*”

Core (25 min)

1. **From elements to qualities — derive on the board.** Don’t just give the answer; ask students to predict.

“*If vāta is space + air — what is wind like? What is space like?*” Take answers. Steer toward:

- dry (air dries skin and laundry)
- cold (a breeze cools you)
- mobile (air moves)
- light (air rises)
- rough (a dry wind is harsh on skin)
- subtle (you don’t see air; you feel it)

“*If pitta is fire + a little water — what is fire like?*”

- hot
- sharp / penetrating (fire cuts through)
- light (flame rises)

- o oily / slightly liquid (the water in pitta gives it fluidity)
- o sour-smelling (sweat, indigestion)

“If kapha is water + earth — what is wet earth like?”

- o heavy (wet earth is heavy)
- o slow (mud moves slowly)
- o cold (cool to touch)
- o oily / smooth (wet clay is smooth)
- o stable (wet earth packs together)
- o dense

2. **Build the canonical table** (students copy into notebooks):

Doṣa	Elements	Three key qualities	Main site in body	One everyday sign
<i>vāta</i>	<i>ākāśa</i> + <i>vāyu</i>	dry, cold, mobile	colon, lower body	dry skin, fast speech, fidget
<i>pitta</i>	<i>tejas</i> + <i>ap</i>	hot, sharp, oily	small intestine, eyes	strong appetite, sharp focus, sweating
<i>kapha</i> <i>a</i>	<i>ap</i> + <i>prthvī</i>	heavy, slow, cool	stomach, chest	steady stamina, heavy sleeper, slow morning

3. **What balance means.** A balanced *doṣa* state is what the body needs to do its job. *Vāta* in balance is *graceful movement*. Out of balance, it is *jittery, jumpy, anxious*. *Pitta* in balance is *clear thinking and strong digestion*. Out of balance, it is *burning gut, sharp irritability*. *Kapha* in balance is *steady stamina and strong immunity*. Out of balance, it is *sluggish, congested, heavy*.

4. **The source paraphrase** (write on the board for students to copy):

“Vāyu, pitta, and kapha — these are declared the summary of the body’s *doṣas*.” — Caraka Saṃhitā, *Sūtrasthāna* 1.59 (paraphrase)

The Sanskrit *pratīka* (cue-phrase) is *vāyuh pittaṃ kaphaścoktaḥ* — “vāyu, pitta, and kapha — declared...” Read it aloud once. Students don’t need to memorise the Sanskrit; the *paraphrase* is enough.

5. **Modern parallel — one line each, no deep dive.**

- o The *doṣas* do not correspond to modern molecules or organs cleanly. They are *functional categories*.
- o The closest modern parallel is **chronobiology** — the study of how the body’s activities cycle through the day. We’ll meet this on Day 5.

Activity (10 min) — Three signs hunt

- Working in pairs. On a half-sheet, head three columns: *vāta*, *pitta*, *kapha*.
- In each column, write *one observable sign* of that *doṣa* from someone you know (not yourself). One line each.
- Examples to seed the activity:

- “My uncle eats fast and gets very hungry — pitta sign.”
- “My grandmother walks slowly and sleeps deeply — kapha sign.”
- “My friend talks fast and can’t sit still — vāta sign.”
- **Important** — they are *signs* or *tendencies*, not diagnoses. We’re noticing patterns, not labelling people.

Wrap-up (5 min)

- **Exit ticket** (1 question, 2 min): “In one sentence — what is one quality of each *doṣa*? Use the words on the board.”
- Collect.
- Preview Day 3: “Tomorrow — your own tendencies. Carefully.”

Student-facing content

The three *doṣas* in summary:

Doṣa	Lit.	Elements	Qualities	What you might notice
<i>vāta</i>	“wind”	space + air	dry, cold, mobile, light, rough	fast speech, fidget, dry skin, light sleeper
<i>pitta</i>	“heater”	fire + water	hot, sharp, oily, light	strong appetite, focused, sweats, gets irritable when hungry
<i>kapha</i>	“binder”	water + earth	heavy, slow, cool, oily, stable	calm, steady, deep sleeper, slow to anger, holds weight easily

When in balance, each *doṣa* sustains the body. When out of balance, each causes its own kind of trouble.

— paraphrased from *Caraka Saṁhitā*, *Sūtrasthāna* 1.59

Homework

- Tonight, observe ONE person in your home for 10 minutes (gently — don’t stare). Write one sentence about which *doṣa* their daily pattern reminds you of, and why. (Do **not** tell them.)

Differentiation

- **One tier up:** Look up “biological clock” in any biology resource. Write one sentence connecting it to the *doṣa* idea. (We’ll formalise this on Day 5.)
- **One tier down:** Memorise the three names and one quality each: *vāta* dry, *pitta* hot, *kapha* heavy.

Teacher notes

- Don’t let students start labelling each other publicly. The home observation is *private* writing.
- Some students will see themselves as “obviously *vāta*” because they’re fidgety today. Note: today’s state ≠ baseline. Save this distinction for Day 3.
- The geminate *t* in *pitta* is tricky. Drill it: PIT-tuh, not PIH-tuh.

Citation(s) used in this lesson

- Caraka Saṁhitā, *Sūtrasthāna* 1.59 (paraphrase). See `sources.md`.